

Rhinella marina

Cane toad



Length 2–9 in
(5–23 cm)
Habit Mostly terrestrial
Breeding After rain season
Status Least concern

Location Central America, South America. Introduced to Australia and elsewhere



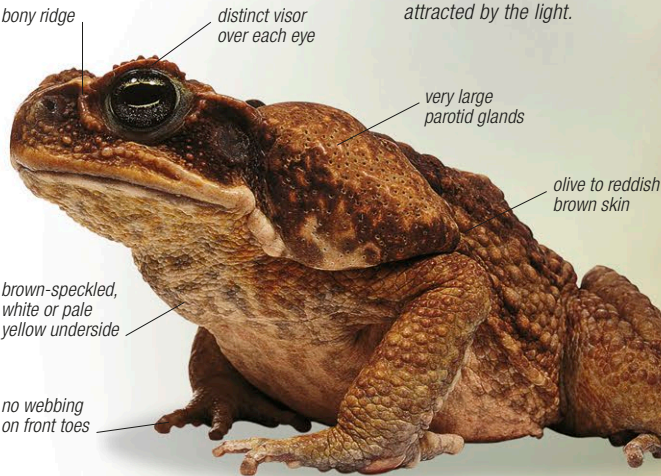
The cane toad is the world’s largest toad. A heavily built creature, it has very tough, warty brown skin that feels leathery to the touch. It has a massive head, with bony ridges above the eyes, and prominent parotid glands that secrete a milky poison whenever the toad is in danger. A hungry feeder, it eats mainly ants, termites, and beetles, but will readily consume a wide variety of other insects and invertebrates as well as other frogs. The cane toad is usually solitary, except in the breeding season. Then males call to females, drawing their attention with a purring trill that sounds like a running motor. The female, which is larger than the male, lays her eggs in long, gelatinous strings, draping them over plants or debris in water. Each clutch may consist of up to 20,000 eggs. In ideal conditions, toadlets will reach adult size within a year of leaving the water. This species has been deliberately introduced into some countries in the hope of controlling insects devastating sugarcane crops—but its predatory nature has devastated native wildlife.

BIOLOGICAL CONTROL

Introduced into Australia in 1935, as well as into many Pacific islands, the cane toad is the target of eradication programs, rather than of conservation. Most of these programs have met with only limited success, since cane toads are highly adaptable and resilient, with a huge reproductive potential. Biological control may be the best way to limit their spread, but as yet no effective method has been discovered that leaves other amphibians unharmed.



VORACIOUS FEEDER
Emerging at night to feed, the cane toad will eat virtually anything it can fit into its mouth, including snakes. In urban areas, they often gather under streetlights, eating insects attracted by the light.



SHORT AND SQUAT
With its heavy, squat body and short limbs, the cane toad is best suited to life on the ground. It usually crawls along or makes short hops.

TOXIC DEFENSE



The cane toad is extremely toxic to other animals. If threatened or squeezed, such as when in the mouth of a predator, it oozes venom from the large glands on its shoulders. Smaller glands over the body also produce venom. Anything swallowing this poison may die very quickly—in as little as 15 minutes in some cases.

FORMIDABLE SURVIVOR
The cane toad is highly adaptable, in terms of both survival and reproduction. It is able to thrive in almost any habitat, and can even tolerate brackish water. It feeds on any animal it can catch, and can survive without water for long periods. Breeding, which produces large quantities of eggs, occurs throughout the year.

